2 Adverbs: Degree, Frequency, Negation and Interrogative

You have already learnt that an ***adverb*** qualifies a verb. An adverb can also be used for other purposes.

Adverbs of Degree/Extent

(One of the meanings of the word 'degree' is 'the amount or level' of something.)

1. Now, look at the following sentences:

   (a) These shoes are too ***big*** *for you.*

   (b) This is a very ***difficult*** *question.*

   (c) The room was quite ***dark*** *and we could not see anything.*

   In *(a)*, the adverb *too* tells us *how* big the shoes are. The adverb *too*, therefore, qualifies the adjective *big*.

   In *(b)*, the adverb *very* tells us *how* difficult the question is—that is, the extent of its *difficulty*. It, therefore, qualifies the adjective *difficult*.

   In *(c)*, the adverb *quite* tells us how *dark* the room was. It, therefore, qualifies the adjective *dark*.

> In all these three cases, an adverb qualifies an adjective and answers the question *'to what extent?'* Such an adverb is known as an adverb of degree.

2. An adverb can also qualify another adverb to indicate *'to what extent'*:

   (d) Kiran did very ***well*** *in the examination.*

   (e) Anand won his match pretty ***easily****.*

In *(d)*, the adverb *very* tells us *how* well Kiran did in the examination. The adverb *very*, therefore, qualifies the adverb *well*.

In *(e)*, the adverb *pretty* tells us *how* easily Anand won his match. The adverb *pretty*, therefore, qualifies the adverb *easily*.

> When an adverb is used in this way to qualify another adverb, it is also known as an adverb of degree.

3. Adverbs of degree can also be used to qualify verbs:

*(f) He really **liked** the song.*	(*How much* did he like the song?)
*(g) Sita almost **fainted** at the news.*	(*To what extent* did Sita faint?)
*(h) We agreed with him **completely**.*	(*To what extent* did we agree with him?)

Warning:

Do not confuse an emphasizing adjective with an adverb of degree. An emphasizing adjective qualifies a noun, whereas an adverb of degree qualifies a verb, an adjective or another adverb.

A ***Pick out the adverbs of degree from the following sentences:***

1. The old lady was almost blind and could hardly walk.
2. The news of her mother's illness upset Vidya greatly.
3. 'I absolutely hate travelling and am completely happy staying at home,' said Kalpana.
4. Jayant is far more interested in physics than in chemistry.
5. Read the question very carefully before you start writing.
6. The sun had nearly set when we reached home.
7. Some modern trains can travel incredibly fast.
8. The judges were utterly amazed at the performance of the young dancer.
9. This chair is extremely comfortable and surprisingly cheap.
10. The bitterly cold winds have killed all the flowers.
11. The road was too narrow for a car.
12. He was so frightened that he did not know what to do.

Adverbs of Frequency

Look at these adverbs:

(i) *Vinod always* ***comes*** *late to school.*

(j) *Hafiz often* ***comes*** *late to school.*

(k) *Sashidharan sometimes* ***comes*** *late to school.*

(l) *Vinit never* ***comes*** *late to school.*

All these adverbs—*always, often, sometimes, never*—tell us how often or frequently something is done or happens.

Adverbs which tell us how often or frequently something happens or is done are known as *adverbs of frequency*.

Do not confuse an *adverb of time* with an *adverb of frequency*. An adverb of time answers the question: *when?* An adverb of frequency answers the question: *how often?*

B ***Pick out the adverbs of time and adverbs of frequency from the following sentences:***

1. 'You must exercise daily to keep fit,' says our PT teacher.
2. Rita is never happy and she continuously complains about others.
3. 'Never say die' really means 'always hope for the best'.
4. Sometimes it is better to keep quiet and listen to what others have to say.
5. People rarely listen to the radio nowadays.
6. Our club is very active and we play in various tournaments regularly.
7. The guards have been repeatedly told to lock the doors and close the windows when nobody is at home.
8. Have you ever heard such a story before?
9. We have music classes twice a week.
10. My father usually goes for a walk in the park.

Adverbs of Negation

(m) *Vimal could not* ***sit*** *for the examination as he was ill.*

(n) *John* ***is*** *not* ***feeling*** *well and wants to go home.*

The word *not* has been used to form the negative of the verb *(could) sit* and *is feeling*. Such a word, like *not*, that is used to form the negative of a verb is known as an ***adverb of negation***.

Interrogative Adverbs

Adverbs which are used to ask *questions* are called *interrogative adverbs*.

(o) *Why have you not done your work?*
(*Why* in this question means *for what reason* (something was not done). It is, therefore, considered to be an adverb of *cause* or *reason*.

(p) *When did Jane come home last night?*
(Similarly, in this question *When* means *at what time*. It is, therefore, acting like an adverb of *time*.)

(q) *Where did the battle take place?*
(*Where* = *at what place*—adverb of *place*)

(r) *How did the thief manage to escape?*
(*How* = *in what way*—adverb of *manner*)

(Please also see Chapter 17, pp 99–102)

Note:

1. *How* can be used with other *adverbs*:

   (s) *How well did Govinda sing?*

   (t) *How hard has Gopalan studied?*

   (u) *How soon can you finish the work?*

2. *How* can be used with *adjectives*:

   (v) *How tall is that building?*

   (w) *How big is the city?*

   (x) *How ill is the patient?*

3. *How* can be used with *much* and *many*:

   (y) *How much sugar have you put into the tea?*

   (z) *How many books have you read this month?*

C ***Fill in the blanks with suitable interrogative adverbs:***

1. ..... did you not report the accident to the police?
2. ..... do you think you will finish reading this book?
3. ..... hard is it raining now?
4. 'Mother, ... are my socks?' asked Vinit.
5. ..... many people turned up to listen to the minister's speech?
6. ..... do some tigers become maneaters?

7. ..... much have you paid for these fancy shoes?
8. ..... did Akbar shift his capital from Delhi?
9. ..... high is Mt Everest?
10. ..... can we meet and go for a swim?
11. ..... did he go after school yesterday?
12. ..... will the shops open in the morning?
13. ..... many questions could you answer correctly?
14. ..... are you looking so sad on such a bright morning?
15. ..... did the thief hide what he had stolen?